THE KICK-OFF



As any self-respecting Bengali will tell you, September 11 is no terror date but the day Swami Vivekananda made his famous speech at the 1893 Chicago World Congress of Religions. The West Bengal BJP has now decided to honour **Narendranath Dutta** (Vivekananda's pre-monk phase name) by kicking off a 'Naren Cup' football tournament that ends on September 17, which just so happens to be PM Narendra Modi's birthday. Not to be out-dribbled, sports minister Aroop Biswas of the TMC has launched a rival 'Swami Vivekananda Cup', starting the very same day, with CM Mamata Banerjee's blessings. Guess it's all about netting pre-poll season goals now.

STARS & SWIPES



Tamil Nadu superstar-turned-neta **Vijay** is already facing jibes for indulging in 'weekend politics' given his policy of scheduling rallies for Saturdays. Yet his maiden rallies in Tiruchy and Ariyalur drew massive crowds, showcasing both his star power and voter curiosity. In Ariyalur, he also turned up the heat on the ruling BJP (Centre) and the DMK (state). The big Perambalur event, however, was cancelled after long will-he-won't-he-make-it postponements, prompting the posters mocking his 'part-time' approach.

RUDE ACCENT



Maharashtra deputy CM and Nationalist Congress Party president **Ajit Pawar**, under fire for ticking off IPS officer Anjana Krishna in a Solapur illegal sand excavation case, has now received support from unexpected quarters. Nephew and MLA from the rival NCP (Sharatchandra Pawar) **Rohit Pawar** has said that the controversy may have happened because of his uncle's wayward style of speaking Hindi. A case of blood being thicker than water or signs of a rapprochement?

Kaushik Deka with Rohit Parihar, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Kavitha Muralidharan and Dhaval S. Kulkarni

HEALTH WATCH

By **Sonali Acharjee**

A NEW CANCER VACCINE? BE CAUTIOUSLY OPTIMISTIC

On September 6, Russia's Federal Medical-Biological Agency said a colorectal cancer vaccine had finished preclinical testing, was 'ready for use' and now awaits regulatory approval; in parallel, other Russian projects, such as the Enteromix platform—a customisable mRNA-based vaccine remain in early trials with viral claims of '100 per cent efficacy'. Dr Pooja Babbar, Head, Medical Oncology, Fortis Hospital Manesar, says, "The Russian mRNA cancer vaccine takes treatment a step further, teaching the body's immune system to recognise and destroy tumors...it may offer lasting protection and real hope for cancer patients."



M ZHAZO

For India, the public health need is stark. In 2022, the country saw some 1.41 million new cancer cases and 916,827 deaths, with 3.3 million people dying within five years of a diagnosis. Cancer also drives profound financial toxicity: recent Indian studies show high out-of-pocket costs (Rs 3.3 lakh per patient annually in some cohorts) and widespread catastrophic health expenditure among cancer-affected households.

Will a Russian cancer vaccine be available in India soon? Not immediately. Any foreign biologic must pass India's regulatory pathway via CDSCO/DCGI (Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation/ Drugs Controller General of India). India can waive local trials for drugs approved in some jurisdictions like the US, EU, UK, Japan, Canada, Australia; Russia isn't on that list. Bottom line: this is an encouraging frontier, but Indian patients must wait for peer-reviewed data and DCGI clearance.